

Tofu with shredded tempeh

Tofu and tempeh? This recipe may sound like a strange combination! In fact, I got the idea after reading a recipe for shredded pork and tofu. The Chinese integrate tofu into their diet, including it in dishes with or without meat. This may seem contrary to vegetarians, as it did to me, until I realized vegetarians are not the only ones to enjoy or desire tofu in their diet.

The bottom line? If you like **spicy** Chinese stir-fry, then this dish is for you. It calls for homemade chili paste, but if you prefer to use store-bought, that's okay. If you've never shredded tempeh, not to worry. Use the larger-size grater, about the size of a hole punch, as opposed to the very fine grater. Serve with plenty of steamed rice.

2 to 3 tablespoons Sweet and Hot Garlic Chili Paste (recipe follows) or jarred garlic chili paste

2 tablespoons plus 1 teaspoon vegetable oil

1 package (8 ounces) tempeh, shredded
[250g]

1 teaspoon salt

About 6 tablespoons vegetable stock

1 large carrot, halved lengthwise and thinly sliced

2 celery ribs, thinly sliced on the diagonal

1 pound firm or extra-firm tofu, pressed of excess water, cut into 1-inch [2.5-cm] cubes
[500g]

1 medium leek (tender white part), thinly sliced and well rinsed

Soy sauce (optional)

1. If making Sweet and Hot Garlic Chili Paste, **do** this first.
2. **Heat** 2 tablespoons of the oil in a wok or large nonstick skillet over medium-high heat. When the oil is very hot and almost shimmering, add the tempeh and sauté until golden brown, 3 to 5 minutes. Stir several times, but allow the tempeh to brown for several seconds on all sides before turning, much like making hash browns. Season with the salt.

3. Add 1 tablespoon of the chili paste and 3 tablespoons of the vegetable stock. Continue to **stir** until they are completely absorbed into the tempeh. Transfer the tempeh to a plate and set aside.
4. Heat the remaining oil in the pan. **Add** the carrot and celery and cook over medium-high heat, stirring often, until the vegetables are slightly softened but still crunchy, about 2 to 3 minutes.
5. Add the tofu and **cook** for another 1 to 2 minutes, until the tofu is lightly browned. Add the leek and continue to cook for another 30 seconds or so, just until the leek begins to soften.
6. Return the tempeh to the pan and **mix** well. Add another tablespoon of chili paste and the remaining stock. Increase the heat to high and stir constantly until the paste and stock are completely absorbed into the stir-fry. Splash with soy sauce, if desired. Serve at once.

SERVES 4 TO 6

